

Sisterhood Saga

A romp into the secret pacts and passions during the blunder years at convent schools

By Geeta Doctor

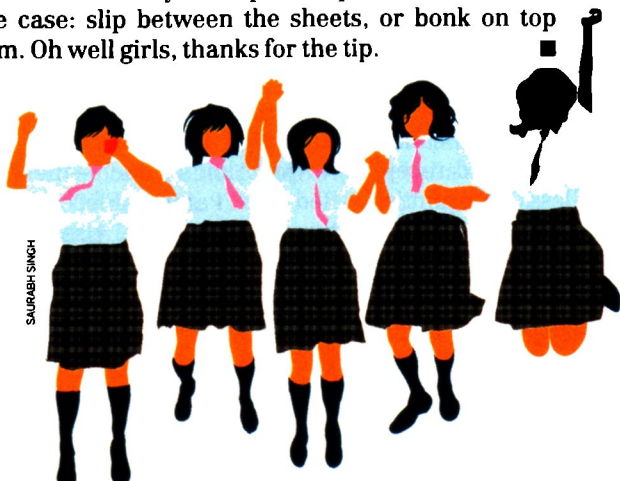
For those who loved the bonding and the bitchery of girls in groups at schools such as the *Sixth form at Mallory Towers* or the going-on at the Chalet School are certain to fall upon Jaishree Misra's saga of the sisterhood with a sense of nostalgia bordering on delight. It's a highly satisfying romp into the secret pacts and passions that made the blunder years at convent schools such a never-to-be forgotten experience. Misra does not leave a single suppurating pimple or acne scar unexplored just as she charts the surge of teenage hormonal desire with all the serious intention of a cardiac physician monitoring a patient in the ICU.

That it is also a convoluted tale that strains the credibility of the reader as she meanders from Delhi to London from time past and time present from the early 1990s when the four heroines were at St. Jude's taking their Board exams and to their lives as glamorous wives and mistresses need not disconcert the complacent reader. Like Shirley Conran, her Brit counterpart who details the lifestyles of the superwomen who want to have it all and usually find a way of getting it, Misra's is a fable of our times. As in Conran's "Jade", the four women have a secret from their collective past that is the poisoned hook on which the story dangles.

She tracks her four girls as they mature into four women all in their mid-30s and presents their pampered lifestyles in a manual of brand images that should earn her a lifetime supply of designer kitchenware, shoes, perfumes and Prada bags. They are equally inventive when it comes to choosing sexual partners. There is much "stirring of the lions" as the Punjabi slang might describe it that seems hopelessly old-fashioned. It's also interesting to note that when passion strikes, our Bengali heroine is worrying whether to fall upon the futon or try and open it up, rather than as used to be the case: slip between the sheets, or bonk on top of them. Oh well girls, thanks for the tip.



SECRETS & LIES
by JAISHREE MISRA
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 275
Pages: 406



TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. Paths of Glory
Jeffrey Archer, Macmillan
2. The Winner Stands Alone
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins
3. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
4. Sidney Sheldon's Mistress of the Game
Sidney Sheldon and Tilly Bagshaw, HarperCollins
5. The Associate
John Grisham, Arrow

NON-FICTION

1. Stay Hungry Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CII, IIM-Ahmedabad
2. Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
3. The Secret
Rhonda Byrne, Atria
4. A Better India A Better World
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane
5. Outliers: The Story of Success
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane

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Amitav Ghosh, Penguin
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Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

NON-FICTION

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Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane
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Amartya Sen, Allen Lane

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